

Weaving the Three Strands

How to build a unit that braids the concept primers, the 250 Voices anthology, and the projects and labs into one arc — so students learn an economic tool, hear the real people who fought over it, and then take a defended stance of their own. A reusable method, plus four units built and ready to teach.

01 The Rhythm — Tool, Argument, Stance

The three strands of this curriculum are not three subjects to cover separately. They are three *moves* in a single thinking process, and a strong unit runs them in order. The concept teaches the tool; the voices stage the argument that tool has always provoked; the project makes the student decide. This is also the C3 inquiry arc — apply disciplinary concepts, evaluate competing evidence, take informed action — in the curriculum's own language.

BEAT 1 · THE TOOL Learn the Concept Open with a concept primer. Students learn how the tool works — what a monopoly is, how compounding runs, why labor isn't an ordinary commodity — and where its neutrality breaks. They now have precise language. <i>Pair with that concept's warm-up.</i>	BEAT 2 · THE ARGUMENT Hear the Voices Bring in 2–4 figures from the 250 Voices who fought over exactly that tool. Students place them on the matrix (Private ↔ Public, Elite ↔ Democratic) and hear the argument run between them. The tool stops being abstract and becomes contested.	BEAT 3 · THE STANCE Take a Position Close with a project, lab, or capstone that forces a decision. Having learned the tool and weighed the arguments, the student now defends their own answer to the unit's question. <i>Pair with the reform-test exit ticket.</i>
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Why this order matters. Lead with voices and the economics stays vague; lead with the project and students argue without tools. The tool first gives them language, the voices give them the range of serious positions, and only then is a defended stance more than an opinion. The rhythm can repeat within a long unit — tool, voices, tool, voices, then one culminating stance — but the order within each loop holds.

02 The Template — Build Your Own Unit

Six steps to assemble any unit from the three strands. The whole method fits on an index card: pick a question, gather the tools, stage the argument, end on a stance.

- 1
- Name the question.** Start with one contested question worth a unit — phrased so a thoughtful person could answer it more than one way. (e.g., "Who should own the value that platforms create?") The anthology's central question — *who holds economic power, and to whom is it accountable?* — is the parent of them all.

- 2

Gather the tools (1–3 primers). Which concepts does a student *need* to reason about this question well? Pull those primers. Two or three is plenty; more buries the argument.
- 3

Stage the argument (2–4 voices). From the 250, choose figures who genuinely disagreed about this — ideally one builder of power and one challenger, so the matrix has real spread. Placement is the activity, not decoration.
- 4

Choose the stance (1 project). Pick the lab, role-play, or capstone that makes students decide. If none fits exactly, the Define & Defend capstone adapts to any unit question.
- 5

Bookend with routines. Open each class with a warm-up (surface prior belief), close with an exit ticket (check learning). The reform-test closer fits almost any unit's final day.
- 6

Sequence the loops. Short unit: one pass through the rhythm. Long unit: alternate tool and voices two or three times, then one culminating stance. Keep tool-before-voices within every loop.

03

Four Units, Built and Ready

Each is a worked example of the rhythm. Teach as-is, or reverse-engineer one to build your own. Every primer, voice section, and project named below is a real piece of this curriculum.

UNIT A • ~2–3 WEEKS

Platforms & Power

Who should own the value that digital platforms create?

TOOLS	Network Effects , Monopoly , and Data primers — why platforms tip toward winners-take-all, and who owns the data that makes them valuable. + What Is a Platform? reader
VOICES	Section IV — The Digital Revolution & Its Critics . Pair a platform builder with a critic; place both on Private ↔ Public and Elite ↔ Democratic. Where does platform power actually sit, and to whom does it answer?
STANCE	The Civic Economy Role-Play Lab (the Data Center Decision) — students negotiate a real platform-economy decision and defend an outcome.
ROUTINES	Open with the Data forced-choice ("your data — yours or the platform's?"); close with the reform test on platform ownership.

The Wealth Divide

Why do owners pull ahead of earners — and what, if anything, should be done?

TOOLS

Wages & Assets, Ownership & Equity, and **Compounding** teach the mechanism; **Predistribution** stages the central reform debate (broaden ownership vs. tax-and-transfer).

+ Movement III: Wealth reader

VOICES

Sections V (**Money, Wealth & Who Controls It**) and VII (**Economic Anger, Identity & Mobilization**) — those who built fortunes beside those who organized against concentration. The matrix spread here is wide.

STANCE

Define & Defend capstone — students argue the smallest reform that would broaden prosperity without breaking the engine that creates wealth.

ROUTINES

Open with the **Predistribution** forced-choice (broaden ownership or transfer?); close with "did your mind move?"

Boom, Bust & Who Pays

If downturns renew the economy, why does it matter who absorbs the cost?

TOOLS

Business Cycles (why economies swing), **Banking & Central Banks** (who governs money and credit), and **Labor** (the three kinds of unemployment, and who bears them).

VOICES

Sections III (**Scale, Labor & the Machine**) and VI (**Power, Accountability & Democratic Renewal**) — the industrialists and the reformers who fought over crashes, money, and who the system protects in a panic.

STANCE

Define & Defend capstone, adapted — students design the smallest cushion for those hit hardest by a downturn that doesn't blunt the cycle's renewing work.

ROUTINES

Open with the **Business Cycles** forced-choice ("recession: system failing or correcting?"); close with the reform test.

The Founding Argument

Where should economic power sit — and to whom should it answer?

TOOLS

The matrix itself is the tool here: **Ownership & Equity** and **Sovereignty** give students the language of power and control before they meet the people who fought over it.

+ Human Flourishing On-Ramp reader

VOICES

Section I — **Architects of the Experiment**. Hamilton vs. Jefferson as the origin of every later fight; the abolitionists and suffragists who demanded the experiment deliver. Place them all; find the argument that never ended.

STANCE

Students write their own placement on the matrix and defend it — establishing the personal stake they'll carry through every later unit. *This unit sets up the whole course.*

ROUTINES

Open with "where should power sit?"; close by having students rewrite the central question in their own words.

Sequencing the four. **The Founding Argument** works as the course opener — it installs the matrix and the central question every other unit returns to. **Platforms & Power**, **The Wealth Divide**, and **Boom, Bust & Who Pays** can run in any order after it, each a self-contained loop of the rhythm. Together they trace the argument from 1776 to the present without ever being merely chronological — because the founding question is still the one being fought over in the platform economy.